

CAD FORUM

DEBATING DOGMA AND DIVISION

Allan Loudon, Editor

Debate by its very nature provokes. Clash and divergence inhere in win/lose confrontations, yet debate is also supremely cooperative, dependent on understandings that synchronized our interactions. Theories of debate practice and purpose have always been a flash point. The debate about debate simultaneously tears at the fabric of community and builds shared norms, an unending search for an “acceptable” balance.

The last decade has been particularly eventful in how the community conceives of the practice and mission of debate. The early outliers of critical challenge have given way to a competitive world in which every debater’s arsenal containing multiple “critical” options. The rapidity of change is mind-boggling with new threads introduced each season that challenge the conventionality of last year’s critical turn. Personalization, projects, and performance have reinvented the “game.”

Some believe that the current state of competitive and ideological positioning is of a magnitude that threatens the very activity we value. Others argue that the academy inspired challenges are a “breath of fresh air” that invigorates an otherwise moribund community. One end of the continuum bemoan that incommensurate world’s obliterate meaningful communication while the other shouts out that rethinking has consequence.

The purpose of this forum is to explore the “schism” that besets current debate, not with the illusion or even desire of resolution but more to formalize some of the conversation that pervades tournament hallways. The authors represented here are not intended to be representative (although there is a considered breadth). They more accurately occupy uncertain space on a continuum of policy to kritik. Even as disagreements remain vitriolic there is also a sense in which voices have also broadened and are more inclusive.

Roger Solt, as is his way, brings to the discussion a lived panoramic view. His assessment of the ideological divide is somewhat stark: “the split in debate between critical and policy approaches has gone beyond culture war to full-blown clash of civilizations.” The article traces the rapidly changing landscape generically referenced as “kritik” debate. Roger’s considerate analysis is hardly neutral, however, as he systematically arraigns each incarnation. The problem of incommensurability, or as Roger puts it “Debate, like chess, is a hard enough game to play without making it a three-dimensional” threatens debate as we know it. His purpose is not to simply reject, however, and he suggests moves toward synthesis.

William (Bill) Shanahan, the resident “father” of the post-modernism incursion into “mainstream” debate theory, receives direct mention from the other essayists, both as innovator and mischievous spirit. Shanahan unabashedly lauds the contribution of various forms of kritik to the community’s argumentative health. He observes, “To consider debate without kritiks, at this time, is like considering a policy alternative by *wishing* away the status quo.” Kritik’s entry into debate in its first and second waves, from Shanahan’s perspective, performs to rescue debate from its own dissolute ineptitude. An extended example illustrates his case: the fallibility of upholding the affirmative resolve for USFG’s regulation of American Indian policy. Almost as intriguing is his foreshadowing of “mainstream” debate moves to “take in” performance and ideological projects. He argues that, “The long-dominant forms of traditional policymaking survived due to an extraordinary ability to *absorb* arguments and practices that threaten it, while maintaining an almost fetishized insularity.” Manifestation of these surreptitious moves is left to be explored at a future point.

Jon Bruschke’s essay is a cryptic, ever personalized, journey through his reflections of what debate ought to be. Bruschke offers up a snappy tour of debate theory’s evolution the last three decades before moving to his primary case: debate is not only about competitive pleasures but more about altering society. He characterizes debate practice as benefiting “a certain class (the debate haves).” Debating intractably rewards privilege and it

is time to seriously consider putting into practice class-based “Affirmative Action.” With care, Bruschke avoids banishing the “haves” from debate, yet to realize openings for classes of student effectively frozen out one is faced with pondering is it will be necessary to exclude in order to include? Perhaps so.

Jeff Parcher, most would agree, is “old school,” more comfortable in a universe where contestants speak in the same language and the measure of what counts has community consensus. The account of his reflexive experiences at Catholic’s 2004 NDT highlights the personal costs when debate becomes less about an abstract universe and more about the qualities of participants themselves. He reflects on what happens when “accusations about privilege, insensitivity, ignorance, racism, hidden political agendas, and . . . personal aspects of individual experience” become the order of the day.

Copyright of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate is the property of Contemporary Argumentation & Debate and its content may not be copied or emailed to multiple sites or posted to a listserv without the copyright holder's express written permission. However, users may print, download, or email articles for individual use.